The other China-directed element involved secret diplomacy. This linked the rapprochement effort with South Asia—not through India, which two decades before had been the mediator, but via Pakistan. Nixon had worried about showing too much eagerness for a rapprochement or offering negotiations only to be snubbed by Beijing—this could negatively affect US prestige abroad and his political prospects at home. There was also a lack of trust in most of the foreign policy bureaucracy. Thus he and Kissinger preferred to move discreetly.[9]

This meant finding a third-country intermediary. While the White House explored a number of options, Pakistan ultimately became the crucial channel. What had earlier been Pakistan's greatest liability in US eyes—its "natural all[iance]" with China—had become its greatest asset. From late 1969 through summer 1971, Islamabad played a critical role in passing Washington's messages to Beijing.

Due to Pakistan's role in the rapprochement effort, Nixon became adamant about the need "to do something" for that country. Subsequently, there was a sense of urgency in the White House to "move" on a broader resumption of military supply for Pakistan.[10] This would have consequences for the US-India relationship.

South Asia had not been a major priority for the incoming Nixon administration in 1969. It had by no means, however, been written out of the script. Nixon intended to develop and maintain good working relationships with India and Pakistan, both of which he perceived as holding some significance—Pakistan in the short term as a channel to China, and India over the long run.[11] For Nixon, even looking beyond Vietnam, Asia was "where the action is." And, as he articulated in a 1967 article, "Any discussion of Asia's future must ultimately focus on the respective roles of four giants": China, India, Japan, and the US. Most of the president's predecessors would not have argued with that statement. Nixon, however, envisioned different roles for each of the giants, especially China. And this altered view of China would have a significant impact on US-India relations.[12]

By the end of the Johnson administration, doubts about India's capacity had considerably eroded its utility as a contrasting model to or bulwark against China. Like Johnson, Nixon found India "both challenging and frustrating: challenging because of its promise, frustrating because of its